DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Who Is the Satan?

Derech Hashem 2:6:3-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 6, paragraph 3 to the end of the chapter **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 19 July 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The last class before the summer

This was the final shiur before the summer break. The Rabbi went back over paragraph 3 and finished Chapter 6. After the break the series would continue with Chapters 7 and 8, on astrology and on a theme that, he said, is what Rosh Hashanah is all about, though the Ramhal does not say so explicitly.

He recalled the system of providence: Hashem made the heavenly court like ours essentially for us to learn that one must consult. There is a head of the court, and every angel looks at a person's deeds from his own perspective, positive or negative, taking into account how and with what motives something was done. Hashem oversees it all but leaves the decision to the courts, unless He is the head of that court or there is a miscarriage of justice.

Paragraph 3: no judgement until someone asks for it

Hashem does not judge the world by His knowledge alone, but through the system He made. Part of that system is that He will not judge until someone comes forward and requests judgement. He created messengers to oversee everything happening in the world, and they bring matters before the court. This, the Rabbi said, is the story of the Satan at the beginning of Iyov, and it is what Rosh Hashanah is about: confusing the Satan, good angels and bad angels. "These are all metaphoric things."

Recall the three things that cause a person's sins to be recalled: walking under a leaning wall, expecting one's prayer to be answered, and handing one's dispute over to Heaven. Hashem knows a person's sins, but they are not brought before Him. Doing one of these three things brings in the malakh, who brings the case, and then the court must judge.

Do the prosecuting angels have free will?

A participant asked whether this implies that the malakhim have free will. The Rabbi said no: they are programmed. "When you see someone behaving in this manner, bring their case to me." A participant compared it to the Crown Prosecution Service: if certain criteria are met, it

must charge; it cannot ignore a murder. That is their job, and so too the malakhim. The prosecuting malakhim bring cases; the defending ones defend.

The Ramhal repeats that Hashem needs none of this, since everything is revealed before Him. He decreed it in His wisdom; why, no one knows, "but probably to teach us a method of how we should judge ourselves."

The verses that describe the system

This system is what Tanakh describes in its metaphoric language: - **The tower of Bavel:** "Hashem came down to see the city." Came down from where? It means: I knew everything, but was not getting involved; now the case has been brought and I must come down and judge. - **Iyov:** the malakhim came before Hashem with a case. Hashem knew, but this is the system. - **Zekharyah:** "the eyes of Hashem roam the earth." The malakhim are called the eyes of Hashem because their role is to go around looking.

A participant asked about the Exodus, where Hashem Himself came down. The Rabbi agreed: there was no court, no malakh, no saraf. "It's me coming and doing it all." That is what was so special about the night of Pesah.

Paragraph 4: only the structure is the same

The Ramhal adds that the comparison with human courts is not completely symmetrical. Only the organisational structure is the same. The details are entirely different: down here it happens among physical beings, up there among spiritual ones.

So Hashem generally oversees things but is not really involved until a case reaches Him, brought by the malakhim. This is what we mean on the Yamim Noraim when we ask Hashem to rise from the throne of judgement and move to the throne of mercy: please do not get involved in judgement.

The chief prosecutor

Among the prosecutors Hashem created a chief prosecutor, the Satan, as at the beginning of Iyov, where the Satan came among the bnei Elohim. The Satan does not choose his role. His role is to go around and bring cases to the courts; "the more cases he brings, the bigger bonus he gets," the Rabbi joked. Once he brings a case, the court cannot ignore it.

The Ramhal calls it part of Hashem's kindness that a person will not face judgement until the prosecutor brings his case, even though all his sins are revealed before Hashem.

Kabbalistic customs and how to live

The Rabbi noted that the Rambam does not accept any of this; it is very kabbalistic. It explains the many kabbalistic warnings not to do certain things at certain times. For example, the Arizal taught not to cut one's nails at night, since night is a time of judgement and nails are associated with judgement, so it is like walking into their territory. If you have done nothing wrong, you need not worry. But we have all done something wrong, and Hashem sometimes overlooks it, and now you are inviting the prosecutor to bring you forward. Similarly the

Gemara in Shabbat says that the angel of death could not take David while he was learning Torah; the moment he stopped, the case could be brought.

The general lesson: "Keep your head down. That's life in general. Do your job and keep your head down. Do your misvot, stay from sin."

But the Rabbi was clear about his own approach. There are hundreds of such things in Kabbalah, and he is generally not particular about them, nor is that how he teaches or rules when asked. We believe in these things, but "you don't live your life like that. You live your life according to Halacha. That's the focus of life." Someone who wants to be extra careful may be. But he questioned customs such as not reading Tehillim or Targum at night: "You're reading Torah. What's wrong with Torah at night?" Some people end up watching TV instead of saying Tehillim. Kabbalah is wonderful, but the question is whether it should be manifested in day-to-day life. The mekubbalim believe so, and the Ben Ish Hai lived that way; most people learn these things theoretically and live normally.

He added a thought to consider: the Gemara in Bava Batra says that the Satan, the yeser hara and the angel of death are one and the same. How that ties together with his role as prosecutor is interesting to think about.

The end of the chapter: rules and times

Even the Satan works within rules. He can prosecute when a person acts dangerously, and there are times when he has more power, which is why we are careful during the Three Weeks. "Again, we have to be careful the way we speak": it is not that he does anything himself, but that it is a time when he can bring cases. There are fixed times of judgement, the world being judged four times a year, and the order of judgement, such as the king being judged first. "Don't think the Satan is in complete control." He is part of the system, but not the sole aspect of it.

The Rabbi closed the term: Part 2 was begun after Pesah, very important things were covered, and Chapters 7 and 8, especially 8, would be finished before Rosh Hashanah.

Summary

- Hashem does not judge until a case is brought by the malakhim He appointed to oversee the world; they are programmed, not free.
- Tanakh's images (Hashem "coming down," the Satan in Iyov, "the eyes of Hashem") describe this system; the Exodus was the exception.
- The heavenly court resembles ours only in structure.
- The Satan is the chief prosecutor; it is Hashem's kindness that no one is judged until he brings a case.
- Kabbalistic customs derive from this, but the Rabbi teaches to live by Halacha and "keep your head down."

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